Part A argument analysis: cram sheet

AP Seminar · end-of-course exam

The workflow (about 30 minutes, 35 at most)

1. **Read and mark (about 5 min):** C at claims, E at evidence, T at the thesis; circle but, however, should.
2. **Default order A3, A2, A1.** A1 always last; A2 or A3 can go first.
3. **Answer in typed, complete sentences.** Full-score answers aren't flawless prose and have no length target.
4. **Final check (2 min):** every piece tied to a claim, real links, whole thesis, no invented credentials.

A3: evidence

6 points · about 11 min

Verdict	Short and qualified: mostly effective, partially successful, falls short.
Each piece	Evidence, the claim it supports, relevance, credibility (author, credentials, organization, date, citation, peer review, possible bias), effect.
Gaps	May or might limit it; never invent details or flaws.
How many	About 4 to 5 is a practice target, not a quota. Mix strong and weak.
2025 Sample A	6 points: weighed specific evidence from several sources on credibility and relevance, including a study's missing name and year.

A2: line of reasoning

6 points · about 10 min

Claims	Major claims, not evidence.
Links	Builds on, deepens, narrows, qualifies, answers an objection, leads to the solution.
No quota	No required stages; never invent a pivot. Order is not connection.
2025 Sample A	6 points: set up the problem, showed later claims deepening it, grouped benefits by stakeholder, tied each group to the thesis.
Sample B	4 points: listed claims in order; linked claims to evidence, not to each other.

A1: main argument

3 points · last, about 2 min

Whole thesis	One or two sentences; the topic alone earns 1. Problem plus solution is a common pattern only when the passage has it.
2025 Sample A	3 points: caught the policy recommendation, the unequal access under unpaid leave, and the benefits to families.

Keywords

use each with a specific link

A3 verdicts	mostly effective · partially successful · credible in some places but lacking in others · falls short · mostly ineffective
A3 checks	expertise or title · organization · date · citation · peer review · possible bias (may, might, could). Missing is not false.
A2 verbs	establishes · contextualizes · elaborates on · illustrates · extends · broadens · narrows in on · qualifies · concedes · refutes · justifies a solution · reinforces

Templates (original; adapt to the passage)

A3 [Evidence] from [source as described] supports [claim] because [link]. [Detail the passage gives] makes it credible, but [gap the passage shows] limits what it proves. No gap? Drop the “but” clause.

A2 [Author] first establishes [claim], which sets up [main argument]. [Next claim] then [extends / narrows / qualifies] that point by [how], so the reader sees [why it matters]. Together, these claims support [main argument] because [why].

A1 [Author] argues [whole central position] because [main reason(s)], with [essential qualification, if present].

Sample notes paraphrase the College Board’s 2025 Part A Set 1 student samples and commentaries (Sample A responses pp. 9 to 10, commentary pp. 14 to 15); scoring per the 2026 scoring guidelines. Order, piece count and timing are study recommendations, not official rules. Practice passage (fictional) and full model answers: on the web guide. A1 to A3: Part A questions 1 to 3; C, claim; E, evidence; T, thesis. valentinoguides.com/seminar-eoc-part-a